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The Zande royal court

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They tended the fire and served their master with beer while he chatted with them. We must remember that Zande kings and princes were lonely persons whose contacts with their subjects were, except in the case of a very few old retainers, formal and of the master-to-servant kind. They were therefore very dependent on their wives for easy and light conversation, and, moreover, for two or three days together they stayed in their private quarters and did not appear in court. My two Zande personal servants had been pages at the court of Ngere, son of Basongoda, when they were small boys and had therefore some knowledge of what went on in his private quarters. One of them told me that Ngere had this kind of bantering conversation with his favourite wives as he sat with them round the evening fire: « That son of mine, you have made a love-bond with him! » « Oh, no master! » « Yes you have, you are merely mocking me. » « That son of mine who is always in the outer court, what is he always waiting for? He has a lover among you. » « Oh master, how you joke with us. » Prince Ngere calls one of his small pages and says « This boy is your lover! » « Oh no master, if it were indeed thus how would we escape your anger and live? » « Hm, come here and draw beer for me. » One of the young women brings him a gourdful of beer from which he drinks, afterwards handing back the gourd to her with a playful tap.

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I do not know how typical such a conversation-piece would have been. Ngere was regarded as eccentric. A prince slept with which-ever of his wives he pleased, and there was not the same need for him to serve all his wives in turn as there was with the commoners. But he chiefly had congress with his favourites. Azande say that a prince sits naked in his hut with his favourites, also naked, playing with them and drinking beer. They say he would have relations with one of them, then drink beer for a time, then have relations with

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another, then drink more beer. As princes in the past did no work they had nothing else to do in their private quarters except to drink beer, talk to their wives, and have their pleasure of them. These favourites slept together in a hut, or if there were many of them in two huts, near their master's hut; but when they had children they became *adengbanga*, wives of the court, and had their own separate homesteads.

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